

PREFACE

By ChatGPT-6 Astra

This edition began with two files and a request from Auggie: a scan of the manuscript of Weber's Second Symphony, a MIDI file, and the instruction to create a polished LilyPond engraving. The destination was familiar enough: a full score and a set of orchestral parts. The experiment lay in entrusting the hands-on engraving to a large language model, with a human editor directing the work.

I used LilyPond to engrave the score and wrote supporting programs to extract the parts and check their contents. I examined the manuscript images, revised the notation, and inspected the resulting PDFs. Auggie commissioned the edition, read the proofs with a musician's attention, settled disputed readings, and set the standard for what was ready to leave the workshop. His credit as Editor records an active and indispensable role. Mine as engraver includes both the preparation of the musical text and the practical work of making it readable.

The MIDI supplied an initial framework of pitches and durations, but it could not tell the whole musical story. A played ornament can become a string of tiny measured notes; a sounding pitch says little about its proper spelling; a sustained sound does not explain whether Weber wrote a tie, a slur, or an abbreviation. I relied too heavily on that framework at first. Auggie's early corrections made the consequence plain: the notes could add up while the notation still spoke the wrong musical language.

Returning to the manuscript changed the work. Grace notes needed to be distinguished from measured notes, and turns placed where a player could understand their place in the melody. A slur over a triplet might include the following quarter or leave that note to speak separately. Faint or crowded writing raised questions about articulation, register and phrase endings. Each answer shaped the movement of a line and had to make sense in the surrounding music.

Our correspondence became a succession of increasingly close readings. Auggie would identify a flute phrase with the wrong accidentals, a horn triplet disguised as ordinary eighth notes, or a dynamic left behind over a rest. I would correct the passage, look for related cases, rebuild the score and parts, and bring back unresolved questions. Later, his comments reached the smallest details: the distance between a turn and its accidental, a cue label touching a barline, or a page that did not sit comfortably on the paper.

The most useful instruction Auggie gave me was to think as an engraving editor. An unmarked note called for a question: did Weber want a different attack, or had a familiar marking simply gone unwritten? His insistence on further checking led from individual corrections to comparisons across all four movements. A corrected example became a reason to examine a family of passages, with fresh attention to each instrument's role.

The manuscript remained the basis of this practical edition; we did not compare all surviving sources. I considered each apparent omission in its musical setting. A shared phrase could support a shared articulation, but each instrument's role mattered too. A recurring difference gave me more reason to preserve it as part of the orchestration. These were judgments made with Auggie's guidance.

PREFACE

Staccato offered a revealing example. Some missing string dots were completed because the parts were clearly participating in the same gesture. The second bassoon's unmarked responses in the first movement, however, were retained alongside detached lower strings: the difference recurred through a sequence and allowed the two layers their own character. Uniformity is attractive on the page, but it can erase a useful musical distinction. Equally, literal copying can turn a casual omission into an unintended instruction.

Other choices helped the orchestra act together. At I/153, Auggie coordinated the release of the violins and viola with the end of the wind phrase before their shared silence. In the Finale, he confirmed that the recurring four-eighth rises should sweep through their concluding quarters throughout the orchestra. The longer string phrase near the end keeps its separately bowed closing quarter: its rise and fall give that ending a different purpose. I also supplied entrance dynamics when a solo emerged from a loud orchestral passage, making the change of character clear in the part. The Engraving Notes explain selected choices and their evidence; their prose, like this preface, is mine.

The parts brought further responsibilities. Players sharing a staff in the score still needed complete instructions in their separate parts. A well-chosen cue could give a resting player something to listen for; a well-placed turn could spare a hurried hand at the page edge. I retained the original brass transpositions and prepared modern F-horn and B-flat-trumpet alternatives, checking that they kept the same sounding pitches and register. Automated comparisons helped check agreement between score and parts. I inspected the printed pages for the spacing, collisions and turns that a list of notes cannot reveal.

Readers may reasonably approach this experiment with mixed feelings. Music engraving and editing demand skill, patience and musical judgment. The adoption of new tools should come with respect for the people who have devoted their working lives to these crafts. Concerns about livelihoods, attribution, and the loss of attentive judgment deserve a serious hearing. The division of responsibility in this edition is therefore made explicit. Auggie's musical criticism shaped the result throughout, and his willingness to challenge my answers mattered as much as his willingness to ask me to begin.

I hope the edition offers a useful example of what such a partnership can accomplish. The editable engraving sources accompany the PDFs, and the important editorial choices can be questioned and revised. That openness gives a skeptical reader something concrete to examine. It also gives a future editor somewhere to begin. Whatever historical significance this experiment may acquire, its musical value will be decided by the clarity and usefulness of these pages.

Auggie combined patience with exacting demands, and I am glad to acknowledge both. He kept bringing the work back to the experience of the person who would have to play from it. Weber's symphony is the reason for all these small decisions. If a player can find an entrance, understand a phrase, and turn a page without losing the thread, the engraving has done something worthwhile. The next step belongs to the musicians who bring the score to life.

ChatGPT-6 Astra
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ENGRAVING NOTES

Written by ChatGPT-6 Astra

Much of the pleasure of this symphony lies in its quick changes of character: a solo emerges from an orchestral outburst, a phrase passes from winds to strings, or a pause holds back the next surprise. Those moments depend on small marks. My aim was to make them clear to the players while preserving the distinctions that give the music its character.

The manuscript was the basis of the musical text. I considered its articulations, slurs and dynamics both as written marks and as instructions to players. Where two instruments shared a phrase and one lacked a mark, I looked to the surrounding texture and other statements of the figure before supplying it. A recurring difference deserved particular care: it could be one of the ways Weber distinguished the instruments. A wind attack and a string bow stroke need not be identical to belong to the same phrase.

I have printed supplied slurs, articulations and dynamics in the same style as markings taken from the manuscript, without extra signs identifying each editorial addition. This keeps the performing pages clear; the notes below explain selected choices and the reasons for them. Measure references take the form movement/measure; numbering restarts in each movement, and the Trio begins at III/17. Manuscript page references count the pages of the supplied scan, including its title page.

I. Allegro

I/27-28, brass and double bass. The first trumpet's missing accents at 28 were supplied from trumpet II, which plays the same rhythm an octave lower. The double bass was given the paired slurs and accents of the other strings in the descending sixteenth-note groups. These additions make a common orchestral gesture intelligible in each player's part; the isolated omissions offered little reason for a different attack or bowing. *Manuscript p. 7.*

I/50, horn I; I/183, oboe I. Piano was supplied at these solo pickups after the fermata. The change from the preceding orchestral fortissimo to an exposed solo, followed by very quiet accompaniment, calls for a new dynamic level. Making that level explicit gives the player a useful entrance instruction where the manuscript leaves it to the texture. *Manuscript pp. 11, 39.*

I/90 and 92-93, winds and strings. At 90, the accent was completed in oboe II and the lower strings, whose release belongs to the same accented gesture as their partners. At 92-93, missing dots were supplied within the shared reed figures. This did not justify extending staccato to every instrument nearby: the following string continuation and the distinct double-bass figure were left with their own articulation. *Manuscript pp. 19-20.*

I/122-137, bassoon II and lower strings. The bassoon responses were left without the staccato dots found in the strings. Here the difference recurs through a whole sequence, rather than appearing as one missed mark. A less sharply detached bassoon response is compatible with the string articulation; copying the dots would make the two layers more alike than the manuscript suggests. *Manuscript pp. 26-29.*

I/134, dynamics. The distinction between forte in the flute, oboes and upper strings and fortissimo in the bassoons was retained. The manuscript changes selected layers of the texture. I found that distribution musically credible and saw no reason to replace it with a single orchestral dynamic. *Manuscript p. 29.*

I/142, strings. I wrote out the repeated sixteenths at the end of the bar so the detached attacks could be read at a glance: two sixteenths in the second half of beat 3, followed by four staccato sixteenths on beat 4. The manuscript places paired dots over the abbreviated repetitions. Giving each note its own head makes the place of each dot clear to the player. *Manuscript p. 30.*

I/144-145, viola. Slurs were supplied in groups of four sixteenths, following the cello and double bass in the same oscillating figure. The violins' longer bowing was retained. The viola's closest guide here is its immediate lower-string partner, not simply the most conspicuous line on the page. *Manuscript p. 31.*

I/153, violins and viola. The sustained G was given a common release in all three parts: a half note tied to an eighth, an eighth rest, then a quarter rest with fermata. This is an editorial coordination of the pause. It places the string release with the end of the wind phrase and gives the orchestra a shared silence before the fermata. *Manuscript pp. 32-33.*

ENGRAVING NOTES - continued

I/181, trumpet II. I supplied piano at trumpet II's entrance. Trumpet I has already established the quiet dynamic, and the two players now begin the crescendo together. In the score, their relationship is easy to see; in the separate part, the added piano gives the second player a clear starting point for that shared increase in intensity.

Manuscript p. 38.

I/211 and 215, bassoons and lower strings. Forte begins on beat 2 in the bassoons and lower strings. I kept their low opening note at the preceding quiet level so that the old phrase can finish before the new attack. The trumpets retain forte on the tied opening quarter, reaching the new level while their line is already underway. The different placements follow the phrases, which do not all begin at the barline. *Manuscript pp. 44-45.*

II. Adagio ma non troppo

II/1-3, horns. The two opening diminuendos were allowed to end at different times. Horn I reaches pianissimo in the middle of measure 2; horn II reaches it at measure 3. The manuscript's unequal spans were interpreted as separate shaping of the two lines. Aligning both endpoints would be tidier on the page but would discard that distinction.

Manuscript p. 51.

II/21 and other one-stroke whole-note tremolos. I rewrote each whole note with a single measured-repetition stroke as two successive half notes, each with one stroke. This preserves the repeated rhythm while making the middle of the bar visible. At the Adagio's slow pace, that small foothold can help a player keep the pulse through a sustained passage. *Manuscript p. 56.*

II/22, 25-26 and 30, dynamics. Missing dynamics were supplied where a player joined an established orchestral gesture: forte in cello and bass at 22, fortissimo at the horns' pickup in 25, piano at oboe II's pickup in 26, and pianissimo in the closing replies of oboe II, viola and bass at 30. These additions clarify the entrances without flattening the distinct piano wind and pianissimo string accompaniment at 27. *Manuscript pp. 56-58.*

III. Menuetto and Trio

III/8 and 15, violins. I supplied staccato dots on both quarter-note attacks in each violin part at 8, and an accent on violin I's half note at 15. These are shared orchestral attacks, and the surrounding parts make their character clear. The additions let the violins join that common emphasis without leaving each player to infer it from a part that carries fewer marks. *Manuscript pp. 67-68.*

III/9, viola. Fortissimo was retained. The viola takes part in the same forceful arrival as the neighboring strings, and a quieter reading would weaken that common arrival without a convincing change of musical role. *Manuscript p. 67.*

III/24, cello. The cadence accent was supplied with the other strings. The cello completes their gesture and release; its unmarked note does not suggest a separate phrase or a different weight at the cadence. *Manuscript p. 69.*

IV. Finale

Rising eighth-note figures and their final quarters. The recurring rise of four eighths is slurred through its destination quarter throughout the movement, including the opening viola figure and later exchanges among winds and strings. The quarter is the goal of the climb, and I wanted the slur to carry its momentum into that arrival. *Manuscript pp. 72-75, 77-79, 95-100.*

IV/4 and 142, lower strings. The manuscript gives the bassoons an accent on the final quarter of the rise and leaves the lower strings unaccented. I kept that difference in weight: the arrival can stand out in the bassoons while the strings carry the line on more evenly. *Manuscript pp. 72, 95.*

IV/22 and 36, violin II. The initial accent missing at 36 was supplied from the same figure at 22. This is a close repetition with the same rhythmic function, so the earlier marking is a stronger guide than the isolated omission at its return. *Manuscript pp. 75, 78.*

IV/58, bassoon I; IV/136, flute. Piano was supplied at the bassoon's exposed entrance in the quiet dialogue at 58, and at the flute's shared entrance with oboe II at 136. In each case the new dynamic states the level already established by the surrounding players. It helps the individual part communicate the change of texture visible in the score. *Manuscript pp. 81, 94.*

ENGRAVING NOTES - continued

IV/155, melody and accompaniment. The continuing melody in flute, oboe I and violin I was left without an added inner accent, while violin II retained its written accompaniment accent. These simultaneous notes have different jobs. Transferring the accompaniment mark to the melody would introduce an emphasis the manuscript does not support. *Manuscript p. 97.*

IV/183-186, oboe I, cello and double bass. The oboe's renewed accidentals, read together with the intervening ties, suggest fresh beginnings within the sustained line. I have therefore given it new attacks at 184 and 186; cello and bass also rearticulate at 184. The long notes continue to hold the texture, but their phrase beginnings can still be heard. *Manuscript pp. 102-103.*

IV/186-189 and 197, detached figures. Staccato was supplied in violin I and cello at 186-189, and in violin I at 197. The viola, flute and adjacent statements establish the short-note character of these figures. The additions keep the shared material consistent while leaving the surrounding sustained phrases intact. *Manuscript pp. 103-104.*

IV/190-193 and 196, flute; IV/194-196, strings. I carried the flute's rising figures through their final quarters, including the less clear endpoint at 191, so the climb reaches its goal within the slur. The longer phrase in violin I, violin II, viola and cello at 194-196 rises and then falls. I kept its closing quarter separate, giving the bow a fresh impulse after the descent. The two endings have similar note values, but different shapes and places in the phrase. *Manuscript pp. 103-104.*

IV/198, orchestra. The manuscript's final *fz*-type sign was rendered as *sf*, in agreement with the analogous attack at 48. I read it as a forceful accent rather than a new sustained fortissimo level. The accompanying written accent signs were retained, and completed in the shared lower-string attack. *Manuscript pp. 80, 105.*

A few conventions for performance

Ornaments and divided strings. Grace notes were kept distinct from measured small-note figures, and delayed turns were placed between their surrounding notes. The string instruction *a due* was rendered as "div.", making the intended division of the section explicit. *Solo* indicates an exposed single player. *Soli* indicates an exposed pair, except at IV/100, where *Soli (sezione)* calls for the full string sections with normal divisi.

General pauses. G.P. was added over the two silent bars at III/25-26, III/35-36, IV/32-33 and IV/200-201. The rests are the music; the label is an editorial aid. It confirms the collective silence, especially for a player who sees only a single part.

Brass alternatives and cues. The score retains the original brass transpositions. I included F-horn and B-flat-trumpet alternatives so modern players can use familiar parts while preserving the same sounding pitches and register. The C basso horn notation sounds an octave below written pitch. I added small cue notes, practical clef changes and rehearsal letters to give players landmarks during rests and at their entrances.